PEER REVIEW HISTORY

BMJ Open publishes all reviews undertaken for accepted manuscripts. Reviewers are asked to complete a checklist review form (**http://bmjopen.bmj.com/site/about/resources/checklist.pdf**) and are provided with free text boxes to elaborate on their assessment. These free text comments are reproduced below.

ARTICLE DETAILS

TITLE (PROVISIONAL)	Sharps injuries and splash exposures among healthcare workers in Arab countries: protocol of a systematic review and meta-analysis
AUTHORS	Karkaz, Ibtisam; Elbarazi, Iffat; Östlundh, Linda; Paulo, Marília Silva; Sheek-Hussein,, Mohamud; Al-Rifai, Rami H.; Adam, Balazs

VERSION 1 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Chuang, Hung-Yi Kaohsiung Medical University Hospital, Department of Occupational and Environmental Medicine
REVIEW RETURNED	12-Aug-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	The protocol will review literature using PRISMA-P guideline to study sharp injuries and splash exposures among healthcare workers in Arab countries. The protocol obeyed PRISMA-P guideline throughout. I have some minor comments: 1. Title: “Sharps injuries” should be sharp injuries. 2. Abstract: Need “Objectives” in abstract. I suggest to separate lines 5-8, “The aim … prophylactic measures.” from “Introduction” to be Objectives. 3. Science the protocol obeys PRISMA guidance, a “PRISMA Flow Diagram” should be included. I suggest to use the form, “PRISMA 2020 flow diagram for new systematic reviews which included searches of databases and registers only”.

REVIEWER	Carter, Gregory Indiana University Bloomington, Community and Health Systems
REVIEW RETURNED	15-Aug-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	Thank you for allowing me to review your manuscript exploring sharps injuries among healthcare workers in Arab countries. You did an excellent job of describing your process as well as paying attention to bias, etc. My only comment centers on the introduction. There are some instances, page 4 line 40, that need citations. And on page 5, line 68, you identify some important statistics; however, it would be helpful for the reader if you include the percent plus the "n". This stood out to me because there is a lack of data, and being able to conceptualize what 35.6% really looks like would be nice. I am looking forward to reading the outcomes of this work. great job.

VERSION 1 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Reviewer 1

Thank you for reviewing our manuscript and providing suggestions for its improvement. Your comments are answered point by point.

1. Title: “Sharps injuries” should be sharp injuries.

‘Sharps injuries’ is the typical term used for injuries caused by sharp objects. Nevertheless, our search includes both words ‘sharp’ and ‘sharps’ to cover any possibilities of phrasing in the literature.

2. Abstract: Need “Objectives” in abstract. I suggest to separate lines 5-8, “The aim … prophylactic measures.” from “Introduction” to be Objectives.

The aim of the study has been placed in a separate paragraph (lines 6-9).

3. Science the protocol obeys PRISMA guidance, a “PRISMA Flow Diagram” should be included. I suggest to use the form, “PRISMA 2020 flow diagram for new systematic reviews which included searches of databases and registers only”.

We thank the reviewer for the suggestion. Our project is currently still in the screening preparation phase and no results are yet available to report in a flow-diagram. As referred to in the ‘Methods’ section (see the introduction of ‘Methods’ (lines 110-115) and the ‘Search strategy’ subsection (lines 167-181)) of our protocol manuscript, we will report the final results of the review in accordance with the new, 2020 PRISMA statement and a flow-diagram describing the findings of the search and selection process will be included as a standard PRISMA reporting item.

Reviewer 2

Thank you for the review and kind evaluation of our manuscript, and for providing suggestions to improve it. Your comments are answered point by point.

1. There are some instances, page 4 line 40, that need citations.

Thank you for this important comment. The text has been rephrased and citations inserted to highlight that, although sharps injuries transmit several pathogens, their role in the transmission of coronaviruses is currently only hypothetical:
‘Sharps injuries are primarily associated with occupational transmission of hepatitis B (HBV), hepatitis C (HCV) and human immunodeficiency virus (HIV), but can also play role in the spread of several other infectious agents.[2] It is a feared, although still only hypothetical, route of transmission of coronaviruses, as well.[3]’ (lines 39-42).

2. And on page 5, line 68, you identify some important statistics; however, it would be helpful for the reader if you include the percent plus the "n". This stood out to me because there is a lack of data, and being able to conceptualize what 35.6% really looks like would be nice.

Thank you for the recommendation. The text has been modified to clarify that the 35.6% sharps injury rate is not an official national value from Egypt in 2003, but a proportion found in a large-scale study among 1485 healthcare workers interviewed:
'In a 2003 Egyptian study conducted among 1485 healthcare workers, 35.6% of the healthcare workers were found to be exposed to needlestick injury during the past three months, with an estimated annual number of nearly five needlesticks per worker.[13]' (lines 71-74).